Buchanan's survey never extended into Travancore, which explains why he remained unaware of the degree to which its Nambudiri Brahmins, in their determination to enforce their version of Hindu law on the local population, had turned themselves into local tyrants.

When the Nambudiris first arrived in Malayala they had found themselves in something of a pickle. By their own interpretation of *varna*, they could not intermarry with the local population because none were worthy of *kshatriya* or *vaisya* status. Even the Nairs, with their sexual habits and their snake-worship, were beyond the pale. Furthermore, the Nambudiris' own customs demanded that only the eldest son of the family be allowed to marry, and only within his own people. It was this that led them to take advantage of the Nair custom of *sambandham*, so that the Nambudiri men could enjoy sexual relations with the Nair womenfolk without being required to reciprocate or to acknowledge any ensuing offspring. As for the Nair men, they made the best of a poor bargain by acting as the Nambudiris' enforcers.

It was not simply that all those deemed to be *avarna* were forbidden to enter Hindu temples. Over the course of several centuries a series of increasingly restrictive measures were brought into Travancore law, all built around the notion of caste pollution, with the single aim of preserving the Brahmins – and, to a lesser degree, the Nairs – from contamination by the rest. Fixed distances of separation were set down, all in multiples of six paces, ranging from six paces from the nearest Brahmin for Nairs to seventy-two paces for those at the very bottom of the ladder, the Paraiyars and others. Nair men could wear moustaches but their inferiors could not, their women could wear silver jewellery but not gold, the rest none at all. Nor could the underclasses carry umbrellas, wear footwear, send their children to school, drink from the public wells, wear new clothes without first making them soiled, put up gates and walls round their houses or use tiles on their roofs. If